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Title:

AN EVENING WITH JULIA MAGGIANO

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Published by

MUSHROOM CLOUD PRESS

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AN EVENING WITH JULIA MAGGIANO

A 10-minute one woman show

By Bridget Grace Sheaff

Bridget Grace Sheaff: DC AREA DIRECTING: Parlor Room: *Burst;* Monumental Theate: *Infinite Future*; Perisphere Theater: *Tartuffe;* Nu Sass Productions: *Exit Carolyn;* We Happy Few: *The Dog in the Manger, A Midnight Dreary;* Spooky Action Theatre: *Motherless Children;* Source Festival*: Static, The Physics of Now, Ball Drop;* REGIONAL: Cape May Stage:*Merry Melodies, Savage in Limbo.* ASSISTING: Constellation Theatre: *The Wild Party.* Signature Theatre: *Titanic;* Spooky Action Theatre: *Collaborators;* Theater J: *Sons of the Prophet;* Rorschach Theatre: *very still & hard to see.* Cape May Stage: *Mistakes Were Made, Other Desert Cities, Blithe Spirit, Moon Over Buffalo.* PLAYWRITING CREDITS: The Strand: *And Maybe a River Will Come;* The Fine Arts Association*: An Evening with Julia Maggiano;* Nu Sass Productions:*The Next Table;* Ohlone College: *Exit Interview*; Gallery Players: *Art of Preservation*. As a playwright, she has published many written works, including *Perfect, Forgive and Forget, love letter to my home town, A Chance of Rain, The Days of Peanut Butter and Honey Sandwiches, Idle Hands, Kissing Lessons, It's Not About the Hair, Danny's How-to-Vlog, The Art of Preservation, The Next Table,* and *Decisions*. Bridget Grace is the casting director and associate producer with We Happy Few Productions and the Casting Manager with Spooky Action Theatre Company. BA 2014, The Catholic University of America.
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A note on form: Ellipses (...) are thoughts not being completed but not necessarily a trailing off. More like shifts in focus rather than intrigue or lack of energy. Think of them as internal pauses. A dash (-) is a self stop. When she self-edits, that's when she completely reverses direction.

Lights come up on a stage set for a one-woman show. There is a high stool, a microphone, a bottle of water. The stage sits empty for just enough too long. CARRIE enters, hesitant and nervous as all get out, but in a rush. She steps up the the microphone.

CARRIE:

Um, hi, hello. (*mic feedback)* Uh, wow. Sorry, I don't… my name is Carrie. I'm um, clearly I'm not Miss Maggiano. I know that. You know that. She knows that, ha, she DEFINITELY knows that. Miss Maggiano is not... She's, uh, she's running SERIOUSLY late. Stuck in traffic, we hope. Um… so, I'm her understudy?

(*pause)*

Right. So. Right. I agree with you. I don't know why she has an understudy on a one woman autobiographical play that she wrote and directed and produced and starred in and yadda yadda yadda. Except maybe for such an occasion… like this one… right now. And even then, I don't…. I don't get it either, really.

But it does seem weird for me to get up and tell you her story because… you came to see her and not me. That's part of the appeal of "An Evening with Julia Maggiano," right? "From the mouth of the star herself." It's on the poster. And, obviously, I'm not the star herself. And I don't have her mouth either. (*reeling)* Sorry. That was a weird thing to say.

(*pause)*

I'm gonna be honest, I didn't even really memorize the play because I thought it was so, uh, ridiculous that the woman even wanted an understudy for her play. I told Jim, the, uh, sorry, he's the stage manager, (*pointing to the back)* he's up there, I told him that there was NO WAY that I was EVER going onstage as an understudy because… because that's an insane thing. I was like "Jim, this is insane. She's insane. Sure, she has five Tony nominations and she's a legend of the American theatre and she once played opposite Richard Burton, but she's MUY LOCA!"

(*pause)*

I minored in Spanish.

I'm, um, stalling. Sorry. No, I'm not sorry. Women apologize too much. That's what everyone says. And so then I feel like apologizing for apologizing too much and then... But that's not about me. Right? That's not… it's about Julia Maggiano. Julia… Maggiano…

Should be here… by now…

So, okay, I know a little bit of the show. I can do the opening monologue part, anyway. If you want. So, okay, for like context I think you have to understand that when Miss Maggiano comes onstage, she's wearing this, uh, it's this black nightie, essentially. It's silky and it's lacy and it's- it's actually really classy. And she's barefoot. And she's holding a whisky glass and she looks amazing because she spent like an hour on her makeup or whatev- she probably doesn't want you to know that, now that I think about it. Sorry. Anyway- So she walks onstage after the lights have come up and she says… I'll do it, hold on, I got it.

> *CARRIE walks off slightly to make an entrance. She dons the Miss Maggiano persona and struts on like she owns the world. Her Miss Maggiano impression is smoky and sultry and, as far as we can tell, spot on. She walks center and plants at the microphone. She takes in the audience, snorts almost haughtily and begins.* ***When CARRIE speaks as Miss Maggiano, the lines are in bold.***

"I've only ever had one great love in my life and that was... the theatre!" (*CARRIE drops character and talks to the audience)* Right? That's like chilling. And identifiable, right? Anyway, so she starts and we are like **"I've only ever had one great love in my life and that was… the theatre! You wouldn't understand it. They always say that you never understand true love until you have children. Well, pardon my French, but that is sheer bull-honky!"** Okay, so she says something other than bull-honky… but I just… There's some really strong language throughout and I don't want to… It's all her. She has a mouth like a sailor, let me tell you. You should hear her when there is mustard on her sandwich.

(*pause)*

Personally, I like mustard. But anyway. So, she basically does this whole first bit where she is talking about how she never got married and never had children and she doesn't feel bad about it at all. She's all "**The only regret I have is that my mother didn't live long enough to realize she would never be a grandmother."**

(*Long pause. This line has upset CARRIE.)*

She's not the nicest lady. I don't know, it seems like she didn't have the greatest relationship with her parents. I had really great parents. Julia- Miss Maggiano, I mean… I don't think I'm supposed to call her Julia. I mean, I feel like I could. I am supposed to pretend to be her. That is the job of an understudy, right? To fill in? But… I don't know. I don't really feel like she and I have all that much in common.

Sorry, this is too much information, isn't it? But I can see Jim in the booth telling me to keep stalling. You can't see him, because he's behind you. Don't turn around, he hates that. No, really, don't. (*trying to get the audience's attention)* No, no, no wait, okay, um… okay. I just broke up with someone! Great… that got your attention.

Uh… I wasn't really going to talk about this because… I'm not really supposed to talk about myself up here. Sorry. I was just… Jim really doesn't like people looking at him.

Okayokayokay, you keep turning around, so fine. FINE. So, there was this guy. And he was my best friend. And he was… he was probably the love of my life, really, and we broke up. That's it. That's the story. It's just like every other story of every other break up. It's really not that interesting. I'm sorry.

No, I'm not sorry. I'm not sorry that it's not interesting because I don't care if you don't find it interesting because this isn't my play anyway so what do I care if you are interested. This is Julia's fault. She's the one who isn't here doing her job.

You know, there's this part in the play, she's basically talking about her work and she has this section- "**You can tell right away who is good and who is coasting by how they treat their work in the theatre. Those who treat it like a game or like a blind date, (*makes throat slitting sound)* ffttt! But, those who treat it like their craft, when it's the thing that makes them get up in the morning, they are the ones who make something extraordinary."**

I hate that. I do. I hate it. She says stuff like that all the time, but you know how she got famous? Her mother paid a director for her first real acting gig. That's absolutely true. Absolutely. (*pointing to the booth)* Jim, shut up, don't even. It's true. She was 15 and she auditioned for *Our Town* and her mother PAID for her to play Emily. I swear it's true. She told me. She told me when she gave me the job she was like, "**Caroline, the theatre is a tricky business. Look at me. My mother scrimped and saved and when the opportunity came along paid my ticket into this business. If you don't have that… well. A credit as my understudy could get you one step closer to doing this the old fashioned way. With grit and sheer will."**

That's not in the play. That actually happened to me. And my name's not Caroline, but whatever. And so, yeah, sure, whatever, I'll understudy for the Gloria Swanson doppleganger. No biggie.

Pete… that's my… was my guy that I broke up with… Pete was like "Carrie, you don't want to do this, why are you? Why are you sacrificing your time when you could be doing something big with your life?" And he never got it. Really. He's not in theatre. So he never really got what it was like to go to an audition and to look at the people across the table who were judging everything you were saying and doing and to just feel so…

Sorry. I don't really want to talk about this. And you don't really want to hear about it, so let's talk about Miss Maggiano some more. Um, so, her mom wasn't always the best influence on her. And she talks about this in the play, so I know it's okay to talk about. Unlike the paying for the *Our Town* thing… Don't spread that around, okay?

Yeah, but, her mom… she sounds like a scary woman. Like she gave Julia diet pills and antidepressants and really just… really just screwed her up a lot, ya know. She has a lot of resentment. Julia, not her mom. Her mom died when Julia was like… I think she says she was 25, right? Jim?

I'm 25 now. How does a 25-year-old get an understudy job for a fifty-fiiii--- (*halfway through realizes she shouldn't say Julia's real age)* forty year old. She's forty.

(*trying too hard to save it)* She doesn't look a day over 37, does she?

But, man, to lose your mom that early? Even, like… even if you didn't like your mom, still. I like my mom. A lot. I love my mom. I can't imagine being without her. Like, when I broke up with Pete, she was the first person I called and she was so great. She was so supportive and compassionate. She told me I had plenty of time.

Plenty of time to have kids and start a family, she meant. Though… She never tells me I have plenty of time to have a career and be an actress. She's always like "Are you sure? What about money, Carrie? What about babies, Carrie?"

Maybe she doesn't really think I have plenty of time after all. And I know, I know she wants to be a grandmother. It's all she talks about with my brother and his wife. And they can't have kids. It's a whole… thing. So it's just me.

Julia says in the play, **"Alone is the place where I thrive. Alone is where I live. Some people vacation in being alone, but I have been paying the mortgage there my whole life."** She doesn't say loneliness… Just alone… Where the hell is Julia?! This is so unprofessional. And inconsiderate. I mean, yeah, whatever, she thought she had hired someone to cover for her if something like this happened, but what did she really think was the best outcome here? And to not even call?

You know that Maggiano isn't even her real last name? It's Bianchi. I don't know why she changed it, but she did. I don't get stage names. I feel like the name you are born with says something about you and if people can't handle that then like, what are we even doing in this business in the first place?

Pete didn't get why I didn't want to take his last name when we got married. (*She stops. She closes her eyes)* Sorry. I just said "when we got married." And clearly we are not. Getting married. And we're not a "we" either. We're not even a "when" anymore. Anyway. He didn't get it and I tried to explain that it wasn't some like feminist statement or anything it's just that if I got gigs and started to really have a career in this thing, then I didn't want my name to change because your name is your brand. Right? You all showed up today because you thought you were going to see Julia Maggiano. "**Julia Maggiano. The name just glides off the tongue, doesn't it?"** She says that in the play, too.

And, okay, I'm sorry. I'm really sorry. I know you paid good money for these seats and you came to see Julia and I should be giving you Julia but you don't want watered-down-Julia from some heartbroken kid who doesn't know what it is like to do this career for longer than 20 minutes. You don't. I promise you you don't. You want Julia! Julia who has preserved and come out the other side. Julia who has seen it all and done it all and said it all. Julia who is… I mean…

She's like, everything all the time. She's a hurricane to be around and I admire her. So much. But, when you aren't looking at her, and Jim, Jim can back me up on this, when you aren't looking, she has the saddest eyes I have ever seen.

Just… heartbroken. **"I don't need anyone else to be happy. Applause gets me there."** (*choking up. Taking a second.)* Sorry.

Jim is waving me down. I think Julia is here. Um… she's gonna need a minute to get ready and I'm sure she has just an amazing, crazy story for where she has been and why she is late. So… if you all could just, sit tight for a second. She'll be right out. Okay? Don't… don't tell her… okay? She's just… you know what, whatever, you can tell her. She should know what I said. I don't… I don't care, I'm done. Thanks. Okay. It'll be just a minute.

> *CARRIE takes a second to see the stage, to feel what it is like to be onstage in front of people, and then exits. The stage is bare. Lights out. END OF PLAY.*